

3.8 Guidance on Internal Assessment

Introduction

The GCE Sciences share a common approach to internal assessment. This is based on the belief that assessment should encourage practical work in science, and that practical work should encompass a broad range of activities. This section must be read in conjunction with information in the Teacher Resource Bank.

Investigative and Practical Skills are assessed in Unit 3 and Unit 6, worth, respectively, 20% of the AS Award (and 10% of the A Level Award) and 10% of the full A Level Award.

There are two routes for the assessment of Investigative and Practical Skills

Either

Route T: Practical Skills Assessment (PSA) + Investigative Skills Assignment (ISA) – Teacher-marked

Or

Route X: Practical Skills Verification (PSV) + Externally Marked Practical Assessment (EMPA) – AQA-marked.

Both routes to assessment are available at AS and A2.

Practical Skills Assessment (PSA)

Candidates following this route must undertake the practical activities outlined in Sections 3.3 for AS or 3.6 for A2 in order to allow candidates suitable opportunities to demonstrate safe and skilful practical techniques and to make reliable and valid observations.

Candidates are assessed throughout the course on practical skills, using a scale from 0 to 6. The mark submitted for practical skills should be judged by the teacher. Teachers may wish to use this section for formative assessment and should keep an ongoing record of each candidate's performance but the mark submitted should represent the candidate's practical abilities at the end of the course.

The nature of the assessment

Since the skills in this section involve implementation, they must be assessed while the candidate is carrying out practical work. Practical activities are not intended to be undertaken as formal tests and teachers can provide the level of guidance that would normally be given during teaching. In order to provide appropriate opportunities to demonstrate the necessary skills, the instructions provided must not be too prescriptive but should allow candidates to make decisions for themselves, particularly concerning the organisation and conduct of practical work, and the manner in